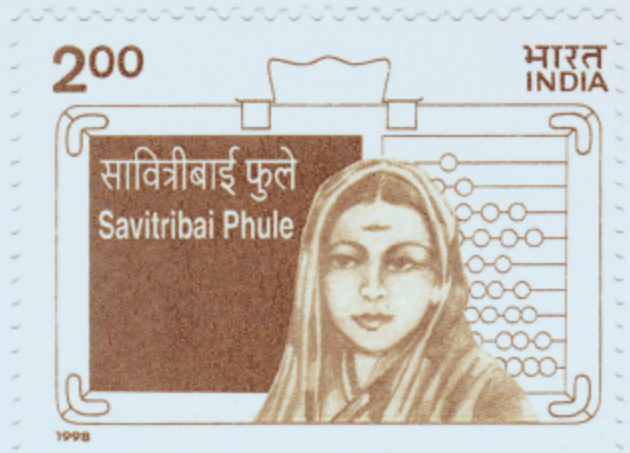


“We shall overcome and success will be ours in the future. The future belongs to us.”

Savitribai Phule, 1856

The majority of women in colonial India had little or no access to education, and hardly any say in when and whom they married. Women could not move about freely in public, and could not divorce or remarry if widowed. They also did not have the right to inherit wealth. In the nineteenth century, the British government in India, foreign missionaries and reformers like Rammohan Roy, Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar, Mahadev Govind Ranade and Jyotirao Phule began to take steps towards social change and improving women’s lives. Largely initiated by men for women, their reforms sought to address oppressive practices but were not always based on a belief in gender equality. Nonetheless, by the time the twentieth century